STORYTELLING THROUGH VISUALS

FROM NUMBERS TO NARRATIVES: PICK THE RIGHT VISUAL

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Choose the Visual. Shape the Story.

A friendly guide for How the right visualizations power clarity and insight in storytelling dashboards.

Objectives

Selecting the appropriate chart is a critical step in data visualization. Although a dataset may be compatible with multiple chart types, identifying the **most effective visual** is essential to ensure accuracy, clarity, and correct interpretation. The responsibility lies with the designer to choose a visualization that communicates insights precisely and avoids ambiguity.

Data delivers value only when it is **properly visualized and contextualized**. Without the right visual framework, even accurate data can lead to misinterpretation or ineffective storytelling.

This guide provides a structured overview of commonly used chart types and outlines practical criteria for selecting the most suitable visualization based on data characteristics and analytical intent.

Visualization Planning Guide

Before creating a chart, it is essential to clearly define its purpose. Charts, maps, and infographics are analytical tools designed to simplify complex data, reveal patterns, highlight trends, and support data-driven storytelling. The first step is to identify the **core message** you want to communicate. Determine the specific insight you want your audience to understand and the key takeaway the visualization should deliver.

Once the message is defined, apply visualization best practices. Ensure data accuracy, validate calculations, and use appropriate scales to preserve analytical integrity. Clearly identify the insight you intend to present—whether comparison, distribution, relationship, or trend—and select a visualization that best supports that objective.

To support effective visual selection, this guide introduces four primary chart categories, each aligned with a distinct analytical purpose.

- **Comparison:**

Comparison charts are designed to evaluate differences across values, categories, or time periods. They help analysts and decision-makers assess how one metric performs relative to another, whether across multiple items or through change over time. By placing data points side by side, these visuals make variations easy to detect, trends quicker to recognize, and relationships simpler to interpret. When used correctly, comparison charts support faster analysis and clearer communication by guiding the audience to understand what is growing, declining, leading, or lagging within the data.

- **Relationship:**

Relationship charts are used to examine how variables interact with one another. Their primary purpose is to reveal whether changes in one variable are associated with changes in another, helping analysts identify correlations, patterns, or dependencies within the data. By visualizing these connections, relationship charts make complex interactions easier to interpret. They support analytical reasoning by showing whether variables move together, diverge, or remain independent enabling more informed conclusions and data-driven insights.

- **Composition:**

Composition charts are used to explain how an overall value is broken down into its contributing elements and how those elements shift over time. Instead of focusing on individual values, these charts emphasize **proportions**, helping viewers understand what makes up the whole and how the balance between components changes. By visualizing structure and share, composition charts make it easier to track growth, decline, or stability within segments. They are especially useful for communicating how priorities, allocations, or distributions evolve supporting clearer insights and more informed interpretation.

- **Distribution:**

Distribution charts are used to understand **how data values are spread across a range**. Instead of focusing on exact totals or comparisons, these charts help analysts see concentration, variation, and frequency within a dataset. They are especially useful for understanding what is typical, what is rare, and where irregular values occur. By visualizing dispersion and density, distribution charts make it easier to detect outliers, assess consistency, and recognize underlying patterns. This insight supports better analysis by revealing whether data is evenly distributed, skewed, or clustered over time or direction.

Type of charts

- **Line chart:**

Line charts are used to track how values evolve across a continuous timeline. They are especially effective for illustrating movement, momentum, and direction making them ideal for monitoring trends such as user activity, performance metrics, or financial fluctuations. By connecting data points sequentially, line charts help viewers quickly understand how something changes rather than just what its value is at a single moment.

When designed thoughtfully, line charts support clear storytelling by emphasizing patterns and shifts without overwhelming the audience. Their strength lies in simplicity: they guide attention to trends, peaks, and declines that matter most to the narrative.

Best Practices for Effective Line Charts:

- **Define the context clearly**
  Label both axes precisely so viewers immediately understand what is being measured and over what period.
- **Reduce visual noise**
  Eliminate unnecessary gridlines, excessive color variations, and oversized legends to keep the focus on the trend itself.
- **Use an appropriate scale**
  If values do not begin near zero, adjusting the y-axis range can improve readability—provided it does not distort the interpretation.
- **Limit the number of lines**
  Display only the series needed to support your message. More than 5–7 lines can reduce clarity and increase cognitive load.

• Pie chart:

Pie charts are designed to communicate **part-to-whole relationships** at a glance. They show how individual categories contribute to a complete total, making them useful when the goal is to emphasize proportion rather than precise comparison. Each slice represents a percentage of the whole, and together all segments form a complete 100%.

Pie charts work best when the message is simple and focused. When used appropriately, they help audiences quickly understand how a total is divided and where the largest or smallest contributions lie.

Best Practices for Effective Pie Charts:

- **Validate proportional integrity**
  Ensure all segments collectively represent 100%. Any mismatch undermines trust and clarity.
- **Limit the number of categories**
  Use only a small set of clearly differentiated slices. Too many segments reduce readability and weaken the message.
- **Choose the right chart for the insight**
  If values are very similar in size or require precise comparison, a bar or column chart often communicates the story more effectively.
- **Keep the design flat and simple**
  Avoid 3D effects, shadows, or tilted views. These distort perception and make it harder to accurately compare proportions.

• Bar chart and Column chart:

Bar and column charts are core comparison tools used to evaluate differences across categories. Both represent values using rectangular bars **column charts display values vertically**, while **bar charts present them horizontally**. The orientation choice depends on readability and context rather than functionality.

These charts are particularly effective when comparing multiple items, ranking values, or displaying clear contrasts. Horizontal bar charts are often preferred when category labels are lengthy or when working with larger item lists, as they maintain readability without clutter. Their straightforward design makes them intuitive for most audiences and well-suited for analytical storytelling.

Best Practices for Effective Bar and Column Charts:

- **Use a zero-based axis for accuracy**
  Always start the value axis at zero. Variations in bar length directly influence perception, and altering the baseline can mislead the viewer.
- **Provide clear axis context**
  Label axes clearly so users immediately understand what is being measured and how values should be interpreted.
- **Display values selectively**
  Including data labels on bars can improve clarity without adding visual noise—especially when precise values matter.
- **Simplify color usage**
  Avoid overusing colors. A consistent color palette maintains focus and reduces distraction. Use accent colors only when you need to highlight a specific data point or insight.

• Treemap:

Treemaps are used to represent **part-to-whole relationships within hierarchical data**. They organize information into nested rectangles, where each rectangle's **size reflects magnitude** and **color conveys category or intensity**. This design allows large and complex datasets to be understood visually, without relying on rows and columns.

Treemaps are particularly effective when working with high-volume data. They enable fast comparison, highlight dominant contributors, and make patterns immediately visible—often in seconds. By efficiently using screen space, treemaps allow analysts to explore thousands (or even millions) of values in a single, structured view.

Best Practices for Effective Treemap:

- **Start with a defined objective**
  Treemaps can become overwhelming without focus. Clearly identify the insight you want to emphasize before selecting or grouping data.
- **Use color with intention**
  Choose a controlled, contrasting color palette to distinguish values or categories. Avoid excessive color variation that can distract or confuse interpretation.
- **Label for quick comprehension**
  Apply clear labels or value indicators to key regions so users can interpret the visual without guesswork.
- **Balance detail and readability**
  While treemaps support large datasets, overcrowding reduces usability. Prioritize meaningful groupings and limit fragmentation where possible.

- ## Dual-Axis chart:

Dual-axis charts are used to compare **multiple metrics with different scales** by plotting them on separate vertical axes within the same view. This approach allows related measures to be analyzed together without flattening or distorting their individual patterns.

While powerful, dual-axis charts must be used with caution. Poor design choices—such as mismatched scales or unclear encoding can mislead viewers or obscure the intended message. When applied thoughtfully, however, they help reveal relationships between measures that would be difficult to interpret in isolation.

The key to effective use is **clarity of intent**: dual axes should support comparison, not create visual competition.

Common Types of Dual-Axis Charts:

- **Column and Line Combination**
  Used when comparing volume against a trend (e.g., sales volume vs. growth rate). Columns provide scale, while the line emphasizes movement over time.
- **Dual Line Chart**
  Displays two time-based measures together for direct comparison. Additional lines may be included selectively, but minimalism is essential to avoid clutter.
- **Dual Column Chart**
  Presents two related metrics side by side using separate axes. Best suited for contrasting values that differ significantly in magnitude.
- **Multi-Axis Chart**
  Incorporates more than two axes to display multiple measures. This format is the most complex and should be used sparingly and only for advanced analytical audiences.

Best Practices for Using Dual-Axis Charts:

- **Use only when scales differ significantly**
  If metrics share a similar range, a single axis is usually clearer and more trustworthy.
- **Clearly distinguish axes and measures**
  Label each axis explicitly and use consistent color mapping to avoid confusion.
- **Limit the number of metrics displayed**
  The more axes involved, the higher the cognitive load. Simplicity improves comprehension.
- **Validate interpretability**
  Ensure the relationship shown supports accurate conclusions, not coincidental alignment.

- ## Area chart:

Area charts are designed to show **how values accumulate and evolve over time**. Like line charts, they trace trends and continuity, but by filling the space beneath the line, area charts place emphasis on **magnitude and volume**, not just direction. This makes them particularly useful when the total impact or scale of change matters more than precise point-to-point movement.

Area charts help viewers quickly understand broader patterns—how much something grows, contracts, or contributes over time—making them effective for high-level storytelling and summary views rather than detailed comparisons.

Best Practices for Using Area Charts:

- **Prioritize clarity over density**
  Avoid overlapping or obscured areas. When too many layers compete for space, key insights become difficult to read.
- **Use stacked area charts intentionally**
  Stacked areas are ideal when you want to highlight how individual components contribute to an overall total across time.
- **Focus on cumulative insight**
  Choose area charts when the total value is the story. If the goal is to highlight precise changes or comparisons, a line chart is often more suitable.
- **Limit the number of series displayed**
  Too many datasets reduce readability. Fewer, well-defined layers support clearer interpretation.
- **Provide strong context**
  Clear labels and legends are essential to help viewers understand what each area represents and how it contributes to the whole.

• Pyramid chart:

Pyramid charts are used to represent **hierarchical structure, progression, or foundational relationships** within data. Their triangular shape visually communicates levels of importance, sequence, or dependency, guiding the audience from a base concept to more specific outcomes—or vice versa, depending on orientation.

These charts are especially effective for illustrating **ranked stages, process flows, or layered concepts**, where each level builds upon the one below. Instead of focusing on precise values, pyramid charts emphasize **order, structure, and proportional significance**, making them ideal for conceptual storytelling and explanatory visuals.

Best Practices for Effective Pyramid Charts:

- **Define the message up front**
  Be clear about what the pyramid represents—whether it's a hierarchy, process, or progression—and ensure each layer directly supports that narrative.
- **Arrange layers by logical priority**
  Order sections intentionally to reflect rank, dependency, or sequence. The visual structure should reinforce meaning without requiring explanation.
- **Maintain visual consistency**
  Use uniform spacing and a cohesive color palette to create balance and improve readability across layers.
- **Limit the number of levels**
  Fewer layers result in clearer communication. Overloading the pyramid with too many sections can obscure the intended message.
- **Label with clarity**
  Apply concise, descriptive labels so viewers can understand each level instantly without confusion.

• Scatter Plot:

Scatter plots are used to analyze the **relationship between two numerical variables**. Each point on the chart represents an individual data record plotted along an x-axis and y-axis, making it easy to observe patterns, correlations, clusters, and outliers within the data.

Scatter plots are especially valuable during exploratory analysis. They help reveal whether variables move together, move independently, or follow a recognizable pattern supporting deeper insights that are not always visible in aggregated visuals like bars or lines.

Best Practices for Effective Scatter Plots:

- **Define the relationship you want to explore**
  Scatter plots work best when there is a clear analytical question, such as correlation, distribution, or clustering.
- **Use clear and meaningful axes**
  Label both axes precisely so viewers immediately understand what variables are being compared.
- **Use color or size intentionally**
  Apply color or sizing to represent additional dimensions (such as category or intensity) but avoid overloading the chart.
- **Highlight patterns, not noise**
  Consider trend lines or reference lines when appropriate to guide interpretation without overpowering the data.
- **Watch for overplotting**
  If many points overlap, use transparency or aggregation techniques to maintain readability.

• Histogram:

Histograms are used to understand **how numerical data is distributed across a range of values**. Instead of comparing individual categories, a histogram groups data into intervals (bins) and displays how frequently values fall within each range. This makes it easier to see the overall shape, spread, and concentration of the data.

Histograms are especially useful for identifying patterns such as skewness, clustering, gaps, and unusual values. They help analysts assess what is typical, what is rare, and how values are dispersed—making them a foundational tool for exploratory data analysis.

Best Practices for Effective Histograms:

- **Choose an appropriate bin size**
  Bin width influences interpretation. Too few bins can hide patterns, while too many can create visual noise. Select a size that balances detail and readability.
- **Use clear axis labels**
  Label the x-axis with the variable being measured and the y-axis with frequency or count to provide proper context.
- **Maintain consistent scales**
  Ensure intervals are evenly spaced so the distribution is accurately represented.
- **Avoid unnecessary styling**
  Simple colors and minimal gridlines help keep focus on the shape of the distribution rather than decorative elements.
- **Use histograms for insight, not comparison**
  Histograms are best suited for distribution analysis. If precise category comparison is needed, consider bar or column charts instead.

• Box Plot:

Box plots are used to summarize the **distribution of numerical data** by highlighting its key statistical characteristics. They display the median, quartiles, spread, and potential outliers in a compact and structured way, making it easy to understand how values are distributed without showing every data point.

Box plots are especially effective for **comparing distributions across categories**. They allow analysts to quickly assess variability, symmetry, and anomalies within data—supporting deeper insight into consistency and deviation across groups.

Best Practices for Effective Box Plots:

- **Use box plots for comparison**
  Box plots work best when comparing distributions across multiple groups, such as regions, products, or time periods.
- **Label axes clearly**
  Clearly define what the values represent and how categories differ to avoid misinterpretation.
- **Interpret outliers carefully**
  Outliers highlight unusual values, but they should be investigated rather than immediately removed.
- **Maintain consistent scaling**
  Use the same axis scale when comparing multiple box plots to ensure accurate interpretation.
- **Keep the design minimal**
  Simple colors and clean layouts improve readability and focus attention on statistical patterns.

• Heatmap:

Heatmaps are used to visualize **patterns, intensity, and relationships across two dimensions** using color variation. Instead of relying on numbers alone, heatmaps leverage color gradients to show how values increase, decrease, or cluster—making complex datasets easier to interpret at a glance.

Heatmaps are particularly effective for identifying trends, concentrations, and anomalies across categories or time periods. They are widely used in dashboards to highlight high-impact areas quickly, such as peak activity times, performance variation, or correlation between metrics.

Best Practices for Effective Heatmaps:

- **Choose a meaningful color scale**
  Use a logical gradient that reflects data intensity (e.g., low to high). Avoid overly bright or rainbow palettes that can obscure interpretation.
- **Ensure consistent scaling**
  Apply a single, well-defined scale so color differences are accurate and comparable across the entire heatmap.
- **Label axes and legends clearly**
  Viewers should immediately understand what each axis represents and what the colors signify.
- **Design for pattern recognition**
  Heatmaps are most effective when highlighting trends or clusters rather than exact values. Use annotations if precise interpretation is required.
- **Avoid excessive granularity**
  Too many rows or columns can reduce effectiveness. Aggregate data where necessary to maintain clarity.

• Funnel chart:

Funnel charts are used to visualize **step-by-step progression through a process**, where values typically decrease at each stage. They help show how a population or quantity moves from one stage to the next, making it easy to identify where drop-offs or losses occur.

Funnel charts are especially effective for process analysis and performance monitoring. Common use cases include sales pipelines, user conversion journeys, recruitment stages, or workflow completion. By clearly illustrating reduction across stages, funnel charts support quick diagnosis of inefficiencies and opportunities for optimization.

Best Practices for Effective Funnel Charts:

- **Define a clear and logical sequence**
  Ensure stages follow a natural order that reflects the real process. Each step should represent a meaningful transition.
- **Use consistent measurement units**
  All stages should be based on the same metric (e.g., count, percentage) to maintain analytical integrity.
- **Limit the number of stages**
  Too many steps reduce readability. Focus on the most important stages that influence decisions.
- **Label values clearly**
  Display counts or percentages at each stage so viewers understand both magnitude and loss.
- **Highlight key drop-off points**
  Use subtle color emphasis or annotations to draw attention to critical stages where significant decline occurs.

• Waterfall chart:

Waterfall charts are used to explain **how an initial value changes over time through a sequence of positive and negative contributions**. Each step shows how individual increments or decrements impact the total, making the progression from a starting point to a final outcome easy to follow.

Waterfall charts are especially effective for **variance analysis and financial storytelling**. They help audiences understand not just the final result, but *why* that result occurred—by clearly breaking down the contributions of each factor.

Best Practices for Effective Waterfall Charts:

- **Define a clear starting and ending point**
  Begin with a baseline value and end with a final total to anchor interpretation and reinforce the narrative.
- **Separate increases and decreases clearly**
  Use consistent color conventions (for example, gains vs. losses) so viewers can instantly distinguish positive and negative impact.
- **Keep the sequence logical**
  Order steps in a way that matches the real-world process or calculation to maintain trust and clarity.
- **Label contributions explicitly**
  Show values for each step so viewers can understand the magnitude of change without estimating.
- **Avoid unnecessary detail**
  Focus on the most influential contributors. Too many steps can dilute the message and reduce readability.

• Gantt chart:

Gantt charts are used to visualize **project schedules, task timelines, and dependencies over time**. They display tasks as horizontal bars plotted against a time axis, making it easy to see when activities start, how long they last, and how they relate to one another.

Gantt charts are especially effective for planning, tracking progress, and communicating timelines to stakeholders. By presenting tasks in sequence, they help users understand workload distribution, identify overlaps or delays, and manage projects more efficiently.

Best Practices for Effective Gantt Charts:

- **Define tasks and timelines clearly**
  Break work into meaningful tasks and assign realistic start and end dates to each.
- **Show dependencies where relevant**
  Indicate task relationships so viewers understand which activities rely on others being completed first.
- **Keep the timeline readable**
  Avoid overcrowding the chart with too many tasks. Group or phase work when necessary.
- **Use consistent labeling**
  Clearly label tasks, dates, and milestones to ensure quick interpretation without confusion.
- **Highlight milestones and progress**
  Use visual markers or color cues to emphasize key deadlines, deliverables, or completed tasks.

• Radar/Spider chart:

Radar charts are used to compare **multiple quantitative variables across a single entity or multiple entities** on a common scale. Values are plotted along radial axes that extend from a central point, forming a web-like shape that makes strengths, weaknesses, and balance easy to observe.

Radar charts are especially useful when evaluating performance, profiles, or capabilities across several dimensions. Rather than focusing on exact values, they help audiences understand **patterns, variation, and overall shape**, making them well suited for high-level comparisons and assessment scenarios.

Best Practices for Effective Radar/Spider Charts:

- **Limit the number of variables**
  Radar charts are most readable with a small set of metrics. Too many axes can make patterns difficult to interpret.
- **Use consistent scales across axes**
  All variables should share the same scale to ensure fair and accurate comparison.
- **Compare only a few entities at a time**
  Displaying too many overlapping shapes can create visual clutter. Focus on the most relevant comparisons.
- **Label axes clearly**
  Each dimension should be clearly named so viewers understand what is being measured.
- **Use subtle color differentiation**
  Apply transparency or muted colors to overlapping areas to maintain clarity without distraction.

• Bullet chart:

Bullet charts are used to evaluate **performance against a target or benchmark** in a compact and efficient format. They display a primary measure (actual value), a reference line (target), and qualitative ranges (such as

poor, average, and good) within a single, simplified view.

Bullet charts are especially effective for **KPI tracking and performance monitoring**. They provide the same insight as a gauge or dashboard tile but with greater clarity and less visual clutter, making them well suited for executive summaries and analytical dashboards.

Best Practices for Effective Bullet Charts:

- **Define the performance metric clearly**
  Ensure the actual value, target, and qualitative ranges are meaningful and aligned with business objectives.
- **Use consistent scales and ranges**
  Apply the same scale across bullet charts when comparing multiple KPIs to preserve accuracy.
- **Keep the design minimal**
  Bullet charts work best with simple colors and clean layouts. Avoid decorative elements that distract from the comparison.
- **Label targets and values clearly**
  Make it easy for viewers to immediately understand current performance relative to goals.
- **Use bullet charts for comparison, not trends**
  Bullet charts are ideal for point-in-time evaluation. For trends over time, use line or area charts instead.

• Dot Plot:

Dot plots are used to **compare values across categories using individual data points** rather than bars. Each dot represents a value plotted along a single axis, making differences between categories easy to see without visual clutter. Dot plots emphasize precision while maintaining a clean and minimalist design.

Dot plots are especially effective when comparing a moderate number of categories or highlighting small differences that may be less noticeable in bar or column charts. By removing unnecessary visual weight, dot plots help viewers focus directly on the data and the story it tells.

Best Practices for Effective Dot Plot:

- **Use dot plots for clear comparisons**
  They work best when comparing values across categories, especially when differences are subtle.
- **Align dots on a common scale**
  A shared axis ensures accurate comparison and prevents misinterpretation.
- **Label values clearly**
  Adding value labels improves clarity without compromising the clean design.
- **Keep the layout simple**
  Avoid excessive colors or decorations. Use color sparingly to highlight key points.
- **Order categories intentionally**
  Sorting categories (for example, highest to lowest) helps guide interpretation and strengthens storytelling.

• Pareto chart:

Pareto charts are used to identify the **most significant factors contributing to a problem or outcome**, based on the Pareto principle (often referred to as the 80/20 rule). They combine a bar chart and a cumulative line chart to show individual category impact alongside the running total.

Pareto charts are especially effective for **prioritization and root-cause analysis**. By highlighting which categories contribute the most to an issue, they help learners and decision-makers focus efforts where they will have the greatest impact.

Best Practices for Effective Pareto chart:

- **Order categories by impact**
  Arrange bars from highest to lowest value so the most influential factors are immediately visible.
- **Use a cumulative percentage line**
  The line helps show how quickly the total contribution accumulates and where diminishing returns begin.
- **Limit categories to meaningful drivers**
  Too many minor categories can dilute the message. Group insignificant values where appropriate.
- **Label clearly and consistently**
  Ensure axes, values, and percentages are easy to interpret without additional explanation.
- **Use Pareto charts for action, not exploration**
  Pareto charts work best when the goal is to decide *what to address first*, not to explore raw data patterns.

• Cohort chart:

Cohort charts are used to analyze **behavior or performance of groups that share a common starting point over time**. A cohort typically represents users, customers, or entities grouped by a specific event—such as signup date, first purchase, or onboarding period—and tracks how that group behaves across subsequent time intervals.

Cohort charts are especially effective for understanding **retention, engagement, and lifecycle patterns**. Instead of looking at overall averages, they reveal how different groups evolve, making it easier to identify trends, improvements, or declines across time-based segments.

Best Practices for Effective Cohort chart:

- **Define cohorts clearly**
  Group entities based on a meaningful and consistent starting event to ensure accurate analysis.
- **Choose the right time interval**
  Use daily, weekly, or monthly intervals depending on the nature of the behavior being analyzed.
- **Use color to show change over time**
  Gradual color shifts help viewers quickly recognize retention strength, drop-off, or improvement patterns.
- **Keep metrics focused**
  Cohort charts work best with a single, well-defined metric such as retention rate, repeat usage, or revenue.
- **Avoid overcrowding**
  Limit the number of cohorts displayed to maintain readability and support clear comparison.

Key Takeaways

- Effective data storytelling starts with understanding the message and audience
- Choosing the right chart improves clarity and prevents misinterpretation
- Simplicity, accuracy, and context are more important than visual complexity
- Each chart type serves a specific analytical purpose—use it intentionally

Chart Selection Summary

- **Comparison:** Bar, Column
- **Trend:** Line, Area
- **Distribution:** Histogram, Box Plot
- **Relationship:** Scatter, Heatmap
- **Composition:** Pie, Treemap
- **Process & Flow:** Funnel, Waterfall, Gantt
- **Performance vs Target:** Bullet
- **Multi-Metric Comparison:** Radar (Spider)
- **Prioritization:** Pareto
- **Retention & Behavior Over Time:** Cohort
- **Minimal Comparison:** Dot Plot
- **Complex Comparison (Use with Caution):** Dual-Axis

Conclusion

This guide provides a structured foundation for selecting the right charts to communicate insights clearly, accurately, and effectively in storytelling dashboards.

Let’s Connect

You’re welcome to reach out with any questions.

"Behind every chart is a story waiting to be seen."